

ECUADOR AND PERU



TOGETHER ECUADOR AND PERU form the western side of equatorial South America, lying between Colombia to the north, Chile to the south, and Brazil and Bolivia to the east. The dominant influences in the west of the region were the Incas, who ruled until the 1500s, and the conquering Spaniards, who imposed their own culture and language. About 40 per cent of the population are *mestizos*, who are people of mixed blood resulting from intermarriage between Spaniards and Incas. Many Native Americans still live in remote Amazonian villages.



Mount Cotopaxi

A perfect cone capped with snow, Cotopaxi, 5,897 m (19,345 ft) is the world's highest active volcano and Ecuador's second highest peak. It lies in the Andes, which form the backbone of both Ecuador and Peru. Ecuador has 15 major volcanoes, ten of which are active. The whole region is shaken from time to time by earthquakes, which cause damage to cities.



Lake Titicaca

At more than 170 km (106 miles) long, Lake Titicaca is South America's largest lake. The Uros people live here on islands that they make from the *totora* reed. They also make reed boats.

Physical features

Lying on South America's Pacific Coast, Ecuador and Peru are dominated by the jagged volcanic peaks of the Andes, whose eastern slopes descend to the hot, humid, tropical rainforest and wetlands of the Amazon Basin. To the west is the coastal strip. Peru's coast is largely arid desert, but Ecuador's coast is hot, swampy, or forested.

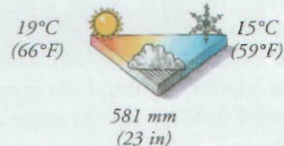


Amazon Basin

The steamy Amazon Basin occupies the eastern regions of Ecuador and Peru. The forest is not an uninterrupted mass of trees, but contains pockets of grassland and swamps. The headwaters of the Amazon originate in this region. Much of this area is disputed territory awarded to Peru in 1942.

Regional climate

Ecuador is hot and humid along the coast, cool and fresh in the Andes, and hot with heavy rainfall in the Amazon Basin. Peru has a more mixed climate. The coastal region is dry, and kept cool by the cold waters of the Peru Current. The western part of the Peruvian Andes is fairly dry, but the eastern Andes and tropical Amazonia have heavy rainfall.



Picking coca leaves, Quillabamba, Peru

Coca

The Incas used to chew coca leaves to relieve fatigue and hunger. Today, in remote areas, coca is grown illegally to produce the powerful and dangerous drug cocaine for supply to the international drug trade. Governments are offering farmers money to destroy their coca crops and grow bananas, cocoa, or coffee instead.